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送信者: POLITICO Pro Article 受信日時: 2026-09-14 22:42

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By Martina Sapio · Sep 14, 2026, 3:42 PM · [View in your browser](#)

ROVANIEMI, Finland — Seven European leaders used a summit in northern Finland on Monday to call for a much stronger EU role in the High North as Russia's military buildup and hybrid activities push Arctic security up the bloc's agenda.

The summit brought together the leaders of Finland, Denmark, Germany, Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia and Romania, as well as French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot, European Council President António Costa and EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas.

"High North and low tension is over," German Chancellor Friedrich Merz told reporters, adding that the region has become a "geopolitical hotspot" due to Moscow's military posture.

Finnish Prime Minister Petteri Orpo said there was "high demand for concrete EU action in the Arctic" and described Russia as the most significant long-term threat to the region's security and stability.

The leaders backed a stronger EU role in the Arctic alongside NATO, with discussions focusing on icebreaking capacity, military and civilian transport links, critical raw materials, energy security and space infrastructure.

Asked whether Europe should develop a common fleet of icebreakers, Merz said the capability was needed across the continent, not only in Nordic countries, and expressed support for a joint project.

Kallas also backed expanding Europe's icebreaking capacity, saying EU leaders agreed that geopolitical tensions, climate change and the opening of new maritime routes meant the continent needs "more icebreakers."

Finland is one of the few countries with the capability to build such ships and is one of the biggest players in the sector, with Finnish companies building around 60% of the world's icebreakers and designing more than 80% of the vessels.

Costa said the priorities discussed at the Rovaniemi summit would also have to be reflected in the EU's next long-term budget for 2028 to 2034.

Brussels is preparing a new Arctic strategy to be released Oct. 20.

Defense Mobility Trade Sustainability Energy and Climate

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